



b. 1967 · co-founder of PayPal and Palantir, venture investor.

"Is your product better — or different?"

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Thiel argues that competition is overrated and that durable value comes from building something so different it amounts to a monopoly.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

From founding PayPal and early investing in technology companies, he developed a contrarian theory of startups built around escaping competition.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the differentiation-and-monopoly reasoning in Unit 4 (moat versus wrapper) and the zero-to-one logic in Unit 7's scaling Slibraries.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His thinking operationalises as the question 'is your product better, or different?' and the pursuit of a defensible niche to dominate.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

His celebration of monopoly is controversial on competition and policy grounds, and 'be different' is more provocation than method.

ENDURING IMPACT

Zero to One became a defining text of startup strategy, popularising the pursuit of differentiation over imitation.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 4)

Jyh-An Lee et al. · Giant 16

Hamilton Helmer · Giant 17

Lawrence Lessig · Giant 19

Andrei Hagiu & Julian Wright · Giant 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Thiel, P. (2014) Zero to One. New York: Crown Business.

Thiel, P. (2014) 'Competition is for losers', Wall Street Journal.